

Then again, I bought Gillette hoping for a long-term profit, but the minute it went up a few points, I started itching to get out. In fact, I was itching to get out of it after three weeks.

When I found out Mr. Blotnick lived in New York and wrote a column in *Forbes* magazine, I called him immediately. I was sorry we couldn't meet in person, but we had a wonderful half-hour phone conversation. He told me his studies were continuing and as far as he knew, average investors were just as likely to lose money now as ever, although in the current market many had gotten temporarily ahead. I told him I hadn't, and that I'd put in hundreds of hours of effort with little to show for it.

"The first 500 hours don't make a great deal of difference," he said.

"No?"

"People who study the market often don't realize this. Five hundred hours of knowledge can be a dangerous thing."

"I can see that."

From here on, Mr. Blotnick sounded more like a guru than an investment counselor. His advice to me was: Know yourself.

"Short-term traders can make money short-term trading," he said. "Long-term traders can make money long-term trading. There are many ways to play the markets, and each one will work for some people but not necessarily for others. If there's any certainty, it's this: People who know who they are and invest accordingly can make money. People who don't know who they are can never succeed. You have to find the method that's right for you and stick to it."

I thought about this hard, and realized the one time I'd made a profit and taken it was the short-term option suggested by Mr. Crawford. It occurred to me that perhaps I was better suited to this sort of short-term trading than I'd imagined.